

Prompting best practices

Prompting is an essential skill for getting the most out of generative AI. To get the best results from an AI tool, you need to craft a good prompt. A good prompt follows a simple framework: **Task**, **Context**, **References**, **Evaluate**, and **Iterate**. Explore how you can use this framework to elevate your prompting and unlock more of AI's benefits.



Specify the task

The first step toward creating a great prompt is to clearly state the task, which is what you want an AI tool to do. Do you want it to draft an email or create an image? Be detailed, and avoid ambiguity, which might result in output that's incorrect or irrelevant.

When you provide an AI tool with a task, also consider including information about:

- **Persona:** What expertise do you want the AI tool to draw from, and who is the audience? For example, you might ask the tool to complete the task with the expertise of an IT professional, or ask it to create an output geared towards a specific audience like your manager or team.
- **Format:** How do you want the output to be formatted? For example, you might ask the AI tool to create a bulleted list or a comparison table.

Those additional pieces of information can help the AI tool accomplish the task the way you want it done.

Here's an example of a prompt that includes a specific **task**, a **persona**, and a **format**:

Task: *Create a social media post about an upcoming music festival that speaks to the local music community while attracting out-of-state festival-goers.*

Persona: *You're a concert promoter specializing in raising ticket sales in the alternative rock music industry.*

Format: *Limit the post to 125-characters. Include 5 relevant hashtags.*

Provide necessary context

Including detailed context in your prompts can narrow an AI tool's focus and tailor its output. Contextual information in your prompts might include:

- Reasons and objectives for performing the task

- Rules or guidelines that the output must follow
- Relevant background information the tool should consider

Those details can help an AI tool better understand your needs. Here's an example of a prompt that provides necessary **context**:

*You're a concert promoter specializing in raising ticket sales in the alternative rock music industry. Create a social media post about an upcoming music festival that speaks to the local music community while attracting out-of-state festival-goers. Limit the post to 125-characters. Include 5 relevant hashtags. **The local audience is primarily college students and young professionals (age 21-35) who follow indie rock. The festival features 12 bands over 2 days, with camping options and local food vendors.***

That prompt is more likely to generate a more engaging and effective output that's tailored to a specific audience—without requiring additional time spent iterating on the initial prompt.

Include references as examples

References are examples or resources that illustrate what you want an AI tool to produce. They specify details about your desired output, such as the style, tone, and format. Depending on the AI tool, you can include text, images, audio, or even video as references.

When including references in your prompts, consider these suggestions:

- Briefly explain how the references relate to the task.
- Use 2-5 high-quality examples that closely align with your needs.
- Include your own work or open-source examples if relevant.

Here's an example of a prompt that includes **references**:

*You're a concert promoter specializing in raising ticket sales in the alternative rock music industry. Create a social media post about an upcoming music festival that speaks to the local music community while attracting out-of-state festival-goers. Limit the post to 125-characters. Include 5 relevant hashtags. The local audience is primarily college students and young professionals (age 21-35) who follow indie rock. The festival features 12 bands over 2 days, with camping options and local food vendors. **Here are examples of successful posts from similar events:***

- Example 1: Where mountains meet music: Indie Rocks Festival returns! Your favorite local bands + national acts. Good eats & Sleep under the stars! #Indie Rocks #SupportLocalMusic

- Example 2: Join Indie Fest under the desert skies! 2 nights of raw sound 2 move you + camping vibes #RoadTrip #CampLife #RockOn

Note: Later in the course, you'll learn more about prompting techniques which leverage references.

Evaluate your output

AI tools vary in their training and capabilities. Each tool has unique strengths and limitations, which can influence the quality of their output. After receiving a response from an AI tool, it's essential to carefully evaluate the quality and effectiveness of the AI-generated content before using it or sharing the output with others.

When evaluating the output, focus on factors such as:

- Accuracy
- Bias
- Relevancy
- Consistency

AI-generated content should serve as a starting point, not a final product. Sometimes while assessing and validating an AI output, you might determine that it's unacceptable or not useful. When that's the case, you should continue on to the next step of the prompting framework.

Iterate for better results

Even well-crafted prompts might not produce ideal results on the first try. This is where iteration comes in—the process of refining your prompt based on the AI's output. Think of iteration like having a back-and-forth conversation with an AI tool. The process typically goes like this:

- You provide an initial prompt.
- The AI tool responds with an output.
- You evaluate the effectiveness of the AI-generated response.
- You refine your request based on what worked and what didn't.
- The process repeats until the AI tool produces the desired results.

Effective prompting is not about getting a perfect result on the first try, but about being willing to continuously improve your approach. Be patient, provide clear feedback, and keep prompting until you reach the desired outcome.

Pro Tip: When you've arrived at an effective prompt for a particular task, save it! You can use your most effective prompts as templates for different use cases and needs. This can help you replicate successful AI-output consistently—without starting from scratch every time.

